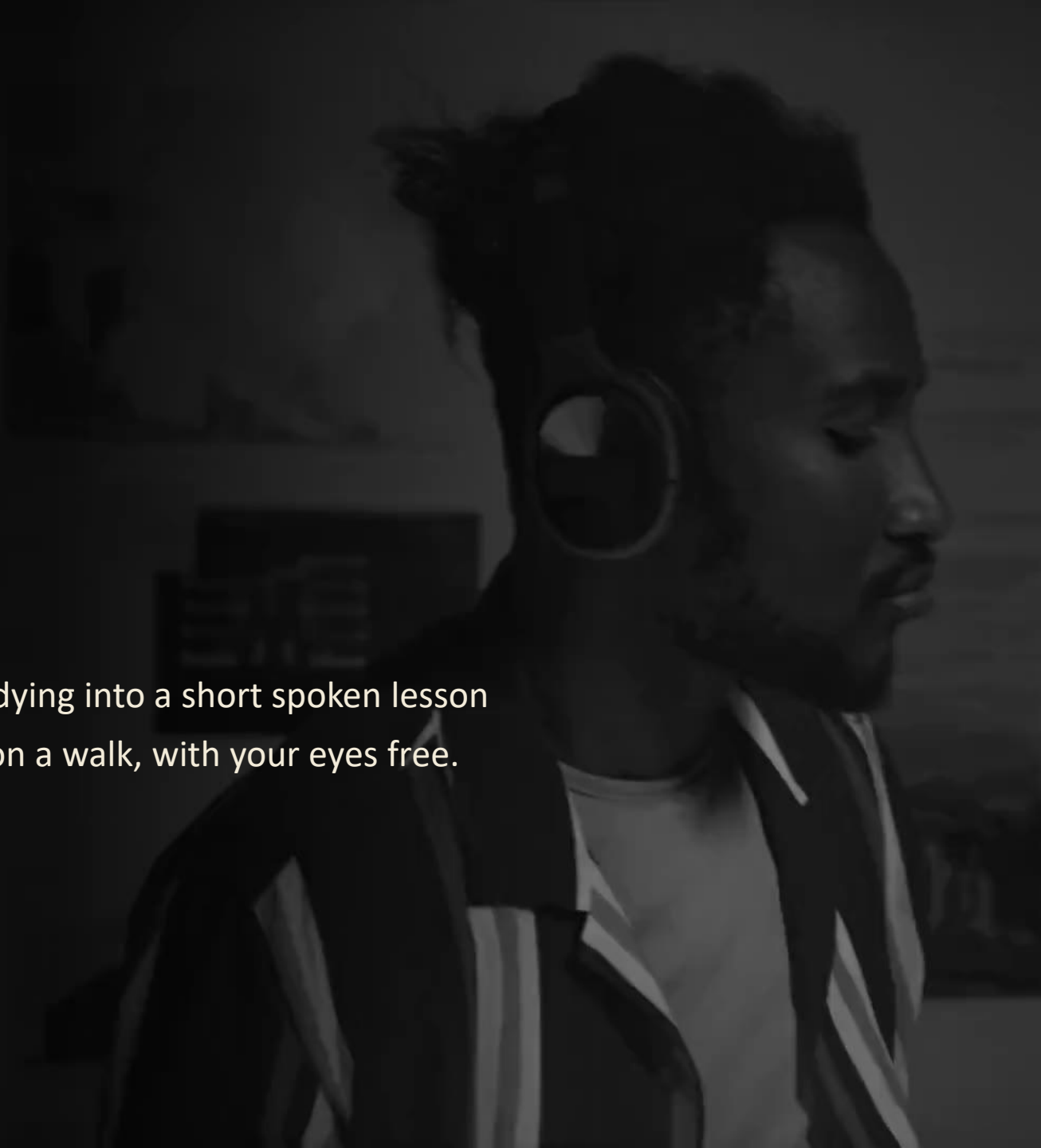


DEEP CUTS

It turns whatever you are studying into a short spoken lesson
you can listen to like a song, on a walk, with your eyes free.

John McSwain

Prof. Niles · August 2026



Learning tools assume your eyes are free. For most adults, they are not.

MY USER

The person who left school, kept a reading list anyway, and gets through four pages a month. They have one subject they cannot put down and no structure left to hold it.

- **Their eyes are committed** Driving, cooking, walking the dog, at the gym.
- **Their hands are committed** So tapping through flashcards is not available.
- **They already tried** And the streak counter told them they failed.



*Eyes and hands already spoken for.
Ears completely free.*

Four projects, and two things I killed.

01

KEPT

a shame-free
commitment app

no streaks, no punishment



02

KEPT × VYBE

merged with
Karen's project

the principle survived another
designer



03

HYPE LAB

voice and music
in a browser

audio can carry feeling



04

DEEP CUTS

the label

all three, aimed at learning

WHAT I KILLED

✗ A chatbot tutor

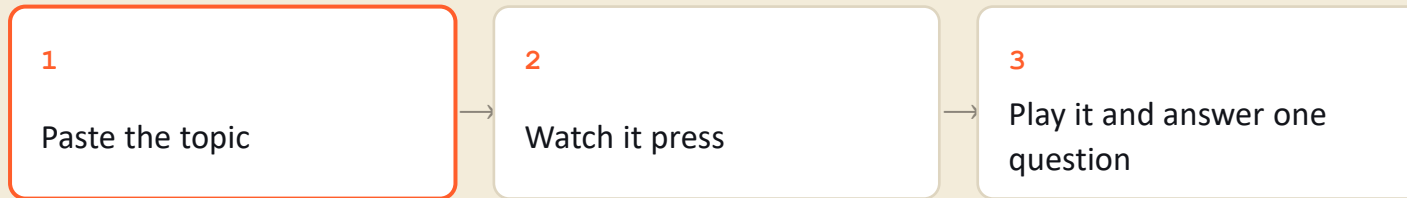
The obvious build, and the one a generic version of me would have made. Killed because it needs your eyes and your hands, which is the exact problem I started from.

✗ The hosted writer

A 550B model behind a Cloudflare relay. Killed after three models, down to 8B, all failed to return a lesson before the browser gave up. The writer now runs on my laptop.

Paste a topic. Get a track.

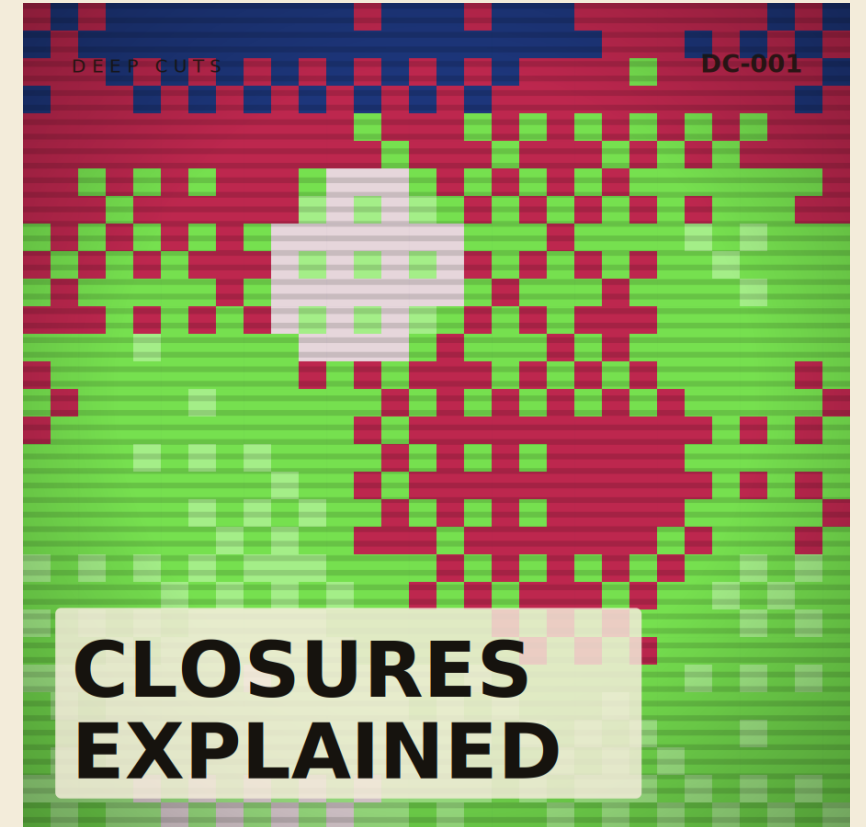
One button produces a spoken micro-lesson, a music bed, a generated sleeve, and questions timed to the beat. A wrong answer costs nothing: the instructor folds the answer back in and the track keeps rolling.



The one path I am walking, start to finish. No feature tour.

If the demo fails

The writer runs on this laptop, so if it stalls the app says so on screen and serves a built-in lesson. Everything after the script still works, and I keep talking.



Every finished track gets a sleeve, generated from its title.

What I put in front of people.

Two sessions. Replace the bracketed text below with what actually happened.

WHO AND WHAT

Secondary and post-secondary learners

FINDING 01

Breadth of requests (explanations, examples, random topics)

No content or topical guardrails applied

FINDING 02

The speed to first token was slower due to the large footprint of the model

Altered the parameters of which model is chosen

REJECTED

Music type selection and discography variety

Lead with the finding that broke an assumption you were confident about.



Deep Cuts is that sentence made runnable. It is live, it presses real tracks, and every fallback in it says so out loud.

- 1 Is the recall question welcome mid-lesson, or an intrusion on something you were enjoying?
- 2 Does the sleeve make a track feel worth keeping, or is it decoration I talked myself into?
- 3 Would you cut a track from your own notes, or only from a topic you name?

